claim over some of the Lok Sabha seats held by the 13 MPs in their camp. A senior leader of Shinde's Sena admitted that despite their faction getting the bow-and-arrow symbol, some incumbent MPs may even want to contest as BJP nominees to get the benefit of any wave in favour of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

There are also murmurs that the BJP leadership is upset with the heft that real estate developer Ajay Ashar carries with Shinde. A close Shinde aide, Ashar's appointment as the vice-chairman of the Maharashtra Institute for Transformation (MITRA), a state planning body on the lines of the NITI Aayog, had raised more than a few eyebrows. The BJP, which had targeted Shinde over his links with Ashar when he was the MVA's urban development minister, is said to be upset with the choice. Later, former IAS official Pravin Pardeshi, who was part of the CM's office when Fadnavis ruled the roost (2014-19), was appointed chairman of MITRA. Pardeshi is reputed to be an aggressive go-getter.

BJP leaders like Thane MLA Sanjay Kelkar are also attacking the functioning of the Thane Municipal Corporation (TMC), which is Shinde's home turf, and party leaders say the central leadership may have a say/veto in deciding who is included in the Maharashtra cabinet from Shinde's faction in the much-delayed expansion of the council of ministers. Some allegations against Shinde's loyalists and ministers Abdul Sattar and Shambhuraj Desai are being attributed to selective leaks from the BJP. In a cabinet meeting, Fadnavis is said to have pulled up Sattar, the agriculture minister, for unilaterally making announcements on policy decisions.

Meanwhile, Fadnavis is none too happy at being relegated as Shinde's No. 2—the latter held the relatively insignificant public works (public undertakings) portfolio when Fadnavis was CM. The rise of Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, a cooperatives baron who belongs to the dominant Maratha caste and joined the BJP from the Congress in 2019, is also being watched keenly in the party. He now holds the crucial revenue portfolio among others, and is said to be a dark horse if ever thoughts of a leadership change firm up on the ground.

Leaders from the BJP and Shinde's party admit that despite the rumblings, they may stick together to keep the MVA out of power. Shinde's political fate, though, hinges on how he handles ties with his ally. "Shinde may have become CM and taken over the Shiv Sena, but his challenge lies in growing the party organisation. Running the government and a party are two different ball games," observed a BJP MLA from Mumbai. The MLA noted that Shinde had no organisational network to speak of and, at best, his group is a loose federation of legislators. Straws in the wind suggest that the BJP leadership may have bigger plans in store for Shinde, who ticks several right boxes since he is a Maratha and a leader with a base in the greater Mumbai region.

Shinde has been described as a workaholic. Hundreds flock to his office on the sixth floor of Mantralaya, the seat of government in Mumbai, and his bungalow 'Varsha' at Malabar Hill for an audience daily. He is said to meet people till the wee hours of the morning. The running joke in the corridors of power is that Shinde probably meets more people in a day than Thackeray—whose inaccessibility was blamed for the midnight coup—did in his entire two-and-a-half-year tenure.

"Shinde is a hard worker. He is a man of the masses unlike Uddhav. His cabin is overflowing with people and he often writes remarks on petitions himself and personally speaks to officials to resolve complaints. But he is not an ideas man and does not know the nuts-and-bolts of the administration," says a BJP minister. Another BJP MLA from Mumbai says Shinde and Fadnavis seemed to have an informal arrangement—while Shinde works as a mass leader and pursues popular politics, Fadnavis would control the levers of government. But the CM's gradual assertion has created some tension.

Shinde loyalist and Aurangabad West MLA Sanjay Shirsat, though, denies this. "There are no differences (between us)," he says. "There is no question (of the BJP) trying to dominate our party...for they had worked the hardest to ensure the Shiv Sena joined hands with the BJP." His party colleague and Buldhana MLA Sanjay Gai-

PAIN POINTS IN SHINDE-BJP ALLIANCE



- Soon after taking charge, BJP leader and deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis snatched the mike from CM Shinde at a press conference, cutting him short. The symbolism was not lost on anyone
- The two are apparently not on the same page when it comes to transfers and postings, including that of police officials. Shinde was reportedly upset at IPS officer Deven Bharti being appointed 'special commissioner' of the Mumbai Police in Dec. 2022. Bharti is said to be close to Fadnavis
- Local BJP leaders have had run-ins with Shinde's ministers like Abdul Sattar
- BJP and Shinde Sena workers were involved in a clash at Magathane in the western suburbs of Mumbai in March. Shinde's MLA Prakash Surve is at odds with ex-leader of the opposition and Fadnavis aide Pravin Darekar
- BJP MLA Mihir Kotecha has alleged graft in the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation, where elections are due. Similarly, BJP MLA Sanjay Kelkar has attacked the functioning of Thane Municipal Corporation, Shinde's home turf